RELATIONSHIPS

The Conflict Resolution Playbook

A practical guide to fighting fair and growing closer through disagreement

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A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear reader,

Every couple fights. The couples who last are not the ones who avoid conflict. They are the ones who know how to fight well. After years of working with couples, I have seen the same patterns over and over: one partner shuts down, the other escalates. Or both avoid the conversation until resentment builds a wall between them.

This playbook is not about eliminating disagreements. It is about transforming them into opportunities for understanding. When you learn to fight fair, conflict becomes the doorway to deeper intimacy, not the exit from it.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Certified Family Counselor*

Section 1: Why You Fight the Way You Fight

Before you can change how you argue, you need to understand what drives your conflict style.

The Four Conflict Patterns

Most couples fall into one of four patterns:

- **Pursue-Withdraw**: One partner chases the conversation while the other retreats. The pursuer feels abandoned. The withdrawer feels overwhelmed. Both feel unheard.
- **Escalate-Escalate**: Both partners match each other's intensity. Voices rise. Words get sharper. The original issue disappears under layers of accusation.
- **Avoid-Avoid**: Both partners sidestep difficult topics. The house is peaceful but the emotional distance grows. Resentment simmers quietly.
- **Demand-Comply**: One partner makes the rules. The other follows to keep the peace. One feels controlled. The other feels unsupported.

Your Conflict Audit

Answer these questions honestly:

1. When we disagree, I tend to: (a) push for resolution immediately, (b) need space first, (c) avoid it entirely, (d) give in to end it
2. My partner tends to: (same options)
3. After an argument, I feel: (a) drained, (b) anxious, (c) disconnected, (d) relieved it is over
4. The topic we avoid most is: _____

Section 2: The Fair Fighting Framework

These five rules transform destructive arguments into productive conversations.

Rule 1: The 24-Hour Cool-Down

If emotions are above a 7 out of 10, stop. Say: "I need to pause this conversation. I care about this topic and I want to discuss it well. Can we come back to it in [specific time]?"

The key: name a specific return time. "Later" feels like avoidance. "Tomorrow at 8pm after the kids are in bed" feels like commitment.

Rule 2: Start with "I" Not "You"

Replace: "You never help around the house." With: "I feel overwhelmed when I handle the housework alone. I need us to find a system that works for both of us."

The formula: "I feel [emotion] when [specific situation]. I need [specific request]."

Rule 3: One Topic at a Time

Arguments spiral when past grievances pile on. If the conversation started about dishes, stay on dishes. Write down other topics that surface and agree to address them separately.

Rule 4: Repair Attempts

A repair attempt is any effort to de-escalate during conflict. Research shows that the success of repair attempts, not the absence of conflict, predicts relationship satisfaction.

Examples of repair attempts:

- "Can I start over? I did not say that well."
- "I can see this is important to you."
- A gentle touch on the arm
- "We are on the same team here."

- Humor (when appropriate and not dismissive)

Rule 5: The Soft Landing

End every difficult conversation with a reconnection gesture. This could be: a hug, a summary of what you heard, an acknowledgment of what was hard, or simply "Thank you for talking about this with me."

Section 3: The Repair Conversation Template

Use this template after an argument that went badly.

Step 1: Acknowledge (2 minutes each, no interruptions) "When we argued about _____, I think I hurt you when I _____. That was not okay."

Step 2: Listen (2 minutes each) "What I heard you say is _____. Is that right?"

Step 3: Own (1 minute each) "My part in this was _____."

Step 4: Request (1 minute each) "Next time, it would help me if you could _____."

Step 5: Reconnect Physical touch, a shared activity, or simply sitting together in silence.

Section 4: Building a Conflict-Resilient Relationship

The Weekly Check-In

Set a weekly 20-minute check-in (not during conflict) to discuss:

- One thing your partner did this week that you appreciated
- One thing you are struggling with (not about your partner)
- One thing you would like to request for the coming week

Knowing When to Get Help

Consider couples counseling if:

- The same argument repeats without resolution
- You have stopped trying to repair
- Contempt (eye-rolling, sarcasm, dismissiveness) has become regular
- One or both partners feel emotionally unsafe
- You are reading this and thinking "it is too late for us" (it probably is not, but that feeling is a signal)

Your Next Step

Conflict is not the enemy of love. Silence is. The fact that you are reading this means you are already choosing connection over comfort. Start with one rule from Section 2 this week. Practice it imperfectly. That is enough.

Ready for Personalized Support?

Your first conversation is free — 30 minutes, no pressure. Let's explore how counseling can help you and your family thrive.

Book Your Free Consultation

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